

Team Writing: Advice

The following sections provide some basic advice on writing in teams and set out some requirements for the formal proposal project specifically. You should also read pp. 148–154 in the textbook (Chapter 8)

Working as a functioning writing team

Everyone is equally responsible for the final product in the assignment. To aid the team as it works together, it is best to assign a project manager. This person can:

- Prepare meeting agendas
- Keep meeting minutes
- Share the task schedule

The project manager (PM) is not the boss, but should guide the group as needed by tracking the status of the project and making sure everyone understands what they should be working on.

Meeting Agendas

The PM should set agendas before meetings so everyone knows the purpose of the next meeting, what will be discussed, and, therefore, what they need to prepare. This will keep group members organized and help them to manage their time.

The agenda can be as simple as:

“We are meeting at/via/on x at time y on date z”

Agenda:

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Contact me if we need to add anything to the agenda.”

Send out the agenda with enough time before the meeting (at least 24 hours).

Meetings

Each meeting should have specific actions that need to be completed. A meeting without actions is essentially a discussion and may be a waste of time.

Take meeting minutes. Add the following information for each meeting:

1. Attendance: names of all attendees
2. Action/agenda Items: this is your list of tasks for the team
3. Any decisions made: if the group makes any changes or new decisions record them and share.
4. Next steps: any questions or actions that need to be completed; include a deadline and person(s) responsible

Make sure each set of minutes is shared to the whole team—within 24 hours is standard.

Task Schedule

Below is a basic task schedule; feel free to come up with something more elegant or extensive, or to use an app or software like Trello or Monday, as long as your instructor has access. If you cannot or do not want to give your instructor access, you will have to submit updated schedules to D2L.

The project manager should record what tasks need to be done, who will do them, by when, and the status of the task. Feel free to reassign roles and tasks as the project develops and you grow to understand the necessary workload for the report sections.

Keep the schedule updated so everyone knows what is going on, including your instructor who will check in with each team from time to time.

The following is a simple task schedule in table form.

Tasks	Who	Deadline	Status
Initial group meeting Decide on proposal topic Write team charter	Everyone		

Consider all possible tasks, for example, the following:

- setting up Google docs if you use this tool
- research: identify current state, problems, costs, schedules, development cycles (including testing, maintenance)
- solutions: generate agreed upon solution to problem
- writing draft sections, summary, letter of transmittal
- formatting (title, toc, lists, references, appendices)
- editing and proofreading (this takes a long time to do well and should be scheduled accordingly)

- designing (e.g. wireframe, mock-ups, site layout)
- submitting the final file
- preparing and practicing the presentation